
POSTMORTEM

THE COST OF THE WORD

What the word actually costs

“Don’t blame people” is not a tone. It is a set of concessions an organisation has to make, and mostly does not. What follows is what they cost, and who has to pay.

BYLINE

Presenter · Team

Source — **none**. No metric, rate or duration appears in this deck; the argument is mechanical.

What a review is for, and what it gets used for

WHAT IT IS FOR

Changing the system

A review earns its hour by changing the thing that failed — a guard, a default, a removed foot-gun. If nothing outside the document changes, the hour bought a document.

WHAT IT GETS USED FOR

Settling whether one person was careless

The room can also answer a cheaper question, and closing it closes the ticket. It ends the search at the first human in the chain, which is never where the chain ends.

HOW TO TELL THEM APART

Read the last paragraph

One review ends in work the system will carry out. The other ends in an assurance that someone now knows better. That is not a control; it leaves with the person.

Three concessions the word actually asks for

CONCESSION ONE

No names in the cause field

A name is not a mechanism. “Ran the wrong command” names where the system allowed it. The field takes conditions: what was reachable, what was open.

CONCESSION TWO

An owner and a date

One person, not a team; a calendar date, not a quarter. When a team owns it, nobody is late, because nobody was ever due. Without both, it is a wish, not a plan.

CONCESSION THREE

A repeat is a new incident

If the same failure returns and nobody reopened the record, it is not the old one again. It is evidence the first fix never landed: new review, new owner, new date.

What makes people tell the truth in one

WHAT THE ROOM IS DECIDING

Every account is a bet

The person who knows what happened is also the person with the most to lose by saying it. They are estimating what the transcript gets used for later, and the estimate is usually right. Change the estimate, not the tone.

FOUR CONDITIONS, NONE OF THEM TONE

It is not evidence. Nothing said here reaches a performance file or a promotion packet.

Not knowing is sayable. “I did not know that flag existed” has to cost nothing to say.

Timeline before conclusion. Order the facts first, or the room reverse-engineers a culprit.

The closest person reads it. Whoever was at the keyboard writes it, or signs it before filing.

Keeping the word, dropping the bill

WHERE IT GOES QUIETLY

Saying it is free

The word survives because saying it costs nothing. The concessions are not free, so the concessions are what gets dropped — quietly, one meeting at a time. Nobody decides to drop them; they are simply never paid.

READ YOUR LAST REVIEW FOR THESE

The cause field says “human error.” The search stopped at the first person it found.

Action items are owned by a team. Nobody is late, because nobody was ever due.

The same failure is filed twice. Two titles, one condition nobody fixed.

What we need to decide

DECISION ONE

Who writes it

The person at the keyboard, the service owner, or an author who was not on the incident? Name the default, and name who may override it.

DECISION TWO

What the deadline is

How many working days from resolution to a filed review? And who is allowed to say it slips, to whom, and on what record?

DECISION THREE

When items are not done

What happens on the date? “Nothing” is a permitted answer. It only has to be the answer we chose out loud, before the date.

Blameless costs three concessions. We pay them, or we stop using the word.
